

DOM in Old Armenian and putative Iranian parallels

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Outline

DOM in Old Armenian

Origin and function of $z=$

Origins of DOM

Iranian parallels?

Conclusions

DOM in Old Armenian

Context

- ▶ The Old Armenian nominal system does not make a morphological distinction between NOM.SG and ACC.SG
(but: NOM.PL often *-kʻ*, ACC.PL *-s*)
- ▶ In view of relatively free constituent order, this is prone to cause ambiguities.

DOM

- ▶ Thus, Old Armenian uses the *nota accusativi* z=, graphically joined to the word/phrase it modifies, to mark *specific* direct objects.
- ▶ This includes: definite direct objects & indefinite specific direct objects.
- ▶ For details and discussion: Müth (2011), Müth (2014) and Scala (2022).

Some examples I

(1) High-definite, specific

... *zi* *z=jer* *awandut'iwn=n* *hastatic'ēk'*
 CONJ **OBJ=2PL.POSS tradition.NOM/ACC.SG=DET** set.2PL.PRS.SBJV
 '... that you may keep your tradition.' (Mk. 7:9)

(2) Low-definite, specific

ew patmeac' *mez* *orpēs etes* *z=hreštak=n* *i tan*
 and tell.3SG.AOR 1PL.DAT how see.3SG.AOR **OBJ=angel.ACC.SG=DET** in house.LOC.SG
iwrum
 REFL.POSS.LOC.SG
 'And he told us how he saw an angel in his house' (Acts 11:13)

Some examples II

(3) Indefinite, specific

ew koč'ec'eal ar ink'n z=mi i carayic'=n ...

and call.PTCP to REFL.NOM/ACC **OBJ=INDF** from servant.GEN.PL=DET

‘And he called to himself one of the servants ...’ (Lk. 15:26)

(4) Indefinite, non-specific

ew berin araji nora xul mi ew hamr

and bring.3PL.AOR before 3SG.GEN **deaf INDF** and dumb

‘And they brought before him a deaf person with a speech impediment’ (Mk. 7:32)

Questions arising I

1. Why did z= come to mark specific objects?
⇒ Etymology, other functions?
2. Is this a typical background and/or trajectory for developing DOM?
⇒ Where do other DOM-markers arise from?
3. Is this a development internal to Armenian?
⇒ Can contact with West Middle Iranian be excluded?

Other uses of z=

As preposition (Jensen 1959: 129–30)

- ▶ + ABL ‘about, concerning’
- ▶ + INS ‘around; with, by’
- ▶ + LOC ‘towards; by’
- ▶ Some instances are essentially the pure case functions, others more nuanced.

Other remarks

- ▶ In its function as *nota accusativi*, z= can (but need not be) be repeated as a quasi-agreement marker, incl. of sentential constituents like relative clauses.
- ▶ For details and a tentative analysis: Meyer (2023a).

Some examples I

(5) + ABL

luaw kin mi z=nmanē
hear.3SG.AOR woman.NOM.SG INDF **about=3SG.ABL**
'a woman heard about him' (Mk. 7:25)

(6) + INS

katakesē en z=novaw
mock.3PL.AOR.SBJV **about=3SG.INS**
'they will laugh about him' (Mk. 10:34)

(7) + LOC

... zi mi erbēk harc'es z=k'ari z=otn k'o
so that NEG ever strike.2SG.AOR.SBJV **at=stone.LOC.SG** OBJ=foot.NOM/ACC.SG 2SG.POSS
'... lest you ever set your foot against a stone' (Mt. 4:6)

Some examples II

(8) OBJ + AGR marking

varesc 'ē *z=tiezerakan* *išxanut* 'iwn=*d* *z=or* *awandea*
 use.3SG.AOR.SBJV **OBJ=comprehensive** power.ACC.SG=DET **OBJ=REL.NOM.SG** give.PTCP
ē *dma* *y=Astucoy*
 be.3SG.PRS 3SG.DAT by=God.ABL.SG
 'He will use his comprehensive powers, which were given to him by God' (Elišē II.130)

Etymology of z=

- ▶ No firm and generally accepted etymology has been established (*tacet* Martirosyan 2010).
- ▶ /z/ could derive from
 - ▶ intervocallic *-ǵ^h-
e.g. Arm. *ezn* ‘ox’, Skt. *ahī* ‘cow’, Mlr. *ag* ‘ox, cow’, Welsh *ael*
Examples are few (Greppin 1980)
 - ▶ an Iranian loanword
e.g. *bazum* ‘much’, cp. Av. *bqz-* “width”, Man. Sogd. *δβ’nz* ‘thick’, Bal. *bāz* “much” (archaic), *bāz* “thick”, etc.
- ▶ The connection with Russ. *za* “to, towards; for”, Lith. *ažù* “behind, after”, Latv. *āiz* “behind, beyond < *ǵ^ho-” vel sim. is problematic for a variety of reasons (*pace* HAB).

Questions arising II

- ▶ Given that all Armenian prepositions are polyvalent as regards case, was the original function of z= prepositional or that of the *nota accusativi*?
- ▶ Given the lack of Armenian-internal information, can typology help in establishing a probable trajectory?
- ⇒ Given the historical morphology of Armenian (final apocope, case syncretism, etc.), DOM seems *a priori* a secondary phenomenon correlated to such changes, predicting a grammaticalisation path ADV → PREP → DOM

DOM

Generally

- ▶ Synchronically, DOM can be triggered by a number of different features including but not limited to specificity, number, animacy, uniqueness, discreteness, discourse roles, TAM, etc. (Witzlack-Makarevich and Seržant 2018)
- ▶ Sinnemäki (2014) indicates that “classical” features (like animacy, definiteness) are cross-linguistically less common causes of DOM.
- ▶ Dalrymple and Nikolaeva (2011) suggest that information structure is a key motivator in the development of DOM (similarity of topical object and subject vs. less canonical objects).
- ▶ Key principles, as already suggested, are disambiguation in combination with economy of markedness (cf. Swart 2007: 87–94).

Specifically

- ▶ Both adpositional and specific case marking of objects are widely attested, e.g. in Turkish, Hindi, Spanish, Coptic, pre-modern Japanese, etc.
- ▶ See recent case studies in Seržant and Witzlack-Makarevich (2018).

Examples I

(9) Spanish (Melis 2018: 98)

- a. *Traj-eron a un amigo con ellos.*
bring-PFV.3PL **DOM** ART.INDF friend with 3PL
‘They brought a friend with them.’
- b. *Traj-eron Ø una maleta con ellos.*
bring-PFV.3PL ART.INDF suitcase with 3PL
‘They brought a friend with them.’

Examples II

(10) Hindi (Montaut 2018: 283–4)

a. *kisī ko bulāo!*

INDF **DOM** call.IMP

‘Call somebody!’

b. *mainē Dilīp ko / (*Dilīp) / Kalkattā dekhā*

1sg.ERG Dilip **DOM** Dilip Calcutta see.PFV

‘I saw Dilip / Calcutta.’

(11) Turkish

çay-ı içtim // çay içtim

tea-DOM drank.1SG.PST tea drank.1SG.PST

‘I drank the (cup of) tea. || I drank tea.’

Implications

- ▶ Although broad motivations are perhaps clear, DOM marking is cross-linguistically too diverse to draw indicative conclusions as to simple developmental paths (cf. e.g. Hindi *ko* < Skt. *kakṣe* ‘armpit’, LOC.SG; cf. Reinöhl 2016).
- ▶ Directionality seems to be one (among many) potential origins. Could this hold for Armenian as well given the prepositional functions of z=?
- ▶ Cf. other uses of ACC (manner, duration) marginally retained with z=:
z=*ays* *ōrinak* ‘in this manner’, z=*amenayn awurs* ‘for all days, forever’.
- ▶ Did PArm. have directional z= + ACC, which ceded its directional functions to *i* and *ar* to take on DOM?

Why seek Iranian parallels?

- ▶ While there is internal motivation for the development of DOM, it is limited (only NOM.SG = ACC.SG, excluding personal pronouns).
- ▶ The West Middle Iranian languages are well known to have exerted considerable influence on the Armenian lexicon (Hübschmann 1875; Hübschmann 1897; Bolognesi 1960), morphology, phraseology and syntax (Meyer 2023b).
- ▶ It stands to reason that potential similarities are worth investigating, whatever be their status (model, influence, parallel, ...).
- ▶ **Caveat:** most WMIr. texts of greater syntactic complexity postdate the earliest Arm. texts; a few long contemporary inscriptions exist.

Example: quotatives I

- ▶ WMIr. uses the complementiser *kw* /*kū*/ to mark both direct statements and direct questions (incl. those with *wh*-words).
- ▶ Etymology: originally interrogative/relative ‘where(?)’, cp. GAv. *kū*
- ▶ Although it is very common, it is not obligatory with direct speech/questions.

(12) Standard COMP

ud kaδ tūrān šāh dīd kū kirbakkar abar āxāšt

and when Tūrān king see.PTCP **COMP** benefactor up rise.PTCP

‘And when the king of Tūrān saw that the benefactor had risen, ...’ (Pth.; M8286/I/R/1–3)

Example: quotatives II

(13) Direct speech

u=š wāžēd kū āfrīd bawāh
 and=3SG.OBL say.3SG.PRS **QUOT** bless.PTCP be.2SG.SBJV
 ‘And he says to him: Blessed be you!’ (Pth.; M8286/I/V/7–14)

(14) Direct question with *wh*-word

wasnāδ bat zarād kū čē wasnāδ druwišt nē būd
 because PN be-angry.PTCP **QUOT** what because well NEG become.PTCP
 ‘Because of Bat he was/became angry [saying]: Why (lit. because of what) has he not become well?’ (Pth.; MKG 1210–11)

Example: quotatives III

- ▶ A very similar constellation (though with different non-quotative functions) is found in Old Armenian with the complementiser (*e*)*t'ē*.
- ▶ Armenian also uses COMP to mark indirect speech/questions; these are less common and frequently difficult to tell apart from direct ones.
- ▶ For reported speech in Classical Armenian in general, cf. Ouzounian (1992).

(15) Standard COMP

k'anzi gitemk' t'ē na ē čšmarit Astuac
because know.1PL.PRS **COMP** 3SG.NOM be.3SG.PRS true God
'Because we know that he is the true God.' (Ag. §253)

Example: quotatives IV

(16) Direct speech

isk nok'a asēin t'ē cano mez ew hastatea
 PTC 3PL.NOM say.3PL.PST **QUOT** make-know.2SG.AOR.IMP 1PL.ACC and confirm.2SG.AOR.IMP
z=mits mer
 OBJ=mind.ACC.PL 1PL.POSS
 'Then they said: Inform us and confirm our minds ...' (Ag. §245)

(17) Direct question with *wh*-word

ew ... asē c'=na yoržam i parsik i hołoy=n i veray čemein
 and ... say.3SG.PRS IOBJ=3SG.ACC when in Persian in soil.LOC.SG=DET atop walk.3PL.PST
t'ē andēr? eler im t'snami, Aršak ...
QUOT why become.2SG.AOR 1SG.POSS enemy, PN ...
 'And ... he said to him as they were walking on top of Persian soil: Why did you become my enemy, King Aršak ...?' (P'B IV.54)

Object marking in Western Middle Iranian

- ▶ Parthian, Middle Persian (and Bactrian) have object markers, all of which derive from adpositions.
- ▶ As with Armenian, their development is the result of an increasingly diminished case system.
- ▶ Pth.(/MP?) *w /ō/* ‘to(wards)’ (Durkin-Meisterernst 2014: 330–2)
- ▶ MP *r’y /rāy/* “for (the sake of)” (Jügel 2019)
- ▶ (Bactrian $\alpha\beta$ “to(wards)” (Gholami 2014))
- ▶ Note that object marking is not obligatory (= not fully grammaticalised?) in WMIr. but that late MP shows early tendencies for DOM as regards definite and (mainly) animate objects, likely interpolations from NP speakers.

Examples

(18) Pth. *w* /ō/ – (D)OM

ud ham ō žīrīft, čē pad frēštag-ān wifrāšt bawēd, isxandēnd, ud ō
 and also **OBJ wisdom** REL by apostle-PL proclaim.PTCP be.3SG.PRS mock.3PL.PRS and **OBJ**
adāwīft iškārēnd
community-of-righteous prosecute.3PL.PRS
 “and they also mock the wisdom, which is proclaimed by the apostles, and prosecute the
 Community of the Righteous” (MKG 1682-6)

(19) MP *r’y* /rāy/ – (D)OM

ud pas awēšān mazdēsñān, čiyōn=išān ān saxwan ašñūd, awēšān haft
 and then DEM.PL Mazdayasnian.PL as=3PL.OBL DEM word.PL hear.PTCP DEM.PL seven
xwaharān rāy hunsandīh dād
sister.PL OBJ satisfaction give.PTCP
 “And then those Mazdayasnians, as they heard these words, satisfied those seven sisters”
 (AW 2 §7)

Other uses of MP/Pth. *ō*

- (20) Pth. *w* /*ō*/ – direction

ud ō kū šawēh

and **to** where go.2SG.PRS

“And where are you going?” (GW §12)

- (21) MP *w* /*ō*/ – purpose

ud abāg ardaxšīr ō kōxšišn ēstād

and with Ardaxšīr **for** battle stand.3SG.N-PRS

“and he stood with Ardaxšīr [ready] for battle” (KAP 10,16)

Sufficiently parallel?

Pro

- ▶ Iranian–Armenian parallels are well established.
- ▶ Both languages have reduced the morphological transparency of their case system (to differing degrees).
- ▶ Both use an otherwise multifunctional preposition for DOM.

Contra

- ▶ Pth. and MP do not have obligatory (D)OM, for Parthian the question of feature (vs. position) differentiability is still open.
- ▶ The prepositions used in Arm. and MP/Pth. do not have a neat functional match, unless one assumes an archaic and unattested directional sense for z=.
- ▶ The DOM features Jügel (2019) proposes for late MP *r'y* /*rāy*/ [+DEF, +ANIM] do not match those of Armenian [±DEF, +SPEC] (and are too late and spurious anyway.)

(Lack of definitive) Conclusions

- ▶ Both Armenian and West Middle Iranian develop DOM.
- ▶ These languages are known to have been in extensive contact, incl. pattern copying by Armenian of Iranian models.

BUT This is a *necessary* but not a *sufficient* argument for supposing a contact-related explanation of this phenomenon.

- ▶ Contact cannot be *excluded* as a motivating factor.

BUT The two patterns are not perfectly aligned in terms of the features marked.

- ▶ The lack of pre-contact data makes it difficult (if not impossible?!) to determine whether in a prior state, the two systems were more closely aligned (e.g. regarding the use of the prepositions).

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